



OFF-SIDE

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WHEN SPORT LIVES ON THE PAGE

Good sports writing trusts that if the moment is observed closely enough, honestly enough, the feeling will **find its way** to the reader on its own.

There is joy, almost forgotten these days, in reading about sport. Not watching highlights, not scrolling through clips, not consuming the game in fragments, but reading about it. Sitting with words and allowing them to slow the moment down, to give shape to what otherwise flashes past.

The finest sports writing has never tried to compete with the spectacle. It takes you to the ground and places you beside your hero, close enough to see both the genius and the vulnerability that make them human.

That idea runs through Gay Talese's *The Silent Season of a Hero*, his portrait of Joe DiMaggio in *Esquire* magazine in 1966, a good 25 years after his 56-game hitting streak in 1941. He watches an older, retired DiMaggio move, wait, and arrive at the crease. And then he writes: "DiMaggio walked slowly into the cage and picked up (Micky) Mantle's bat. He took his position at the plate but obviously it was not the classic DiMaggio stance; he was holding the bat about two inches from the knob, his feet were not so far apart, and, when DiMaggio took a cut at (coach Vern) Benson's first pitch, fouling it, there was none of that ferocious follow-through; the blurred bat did not come whipping all the way around; the No. 5 was not stretched full across his broad back.

"DiMaggio fouled Benson's second pitch, then he connected solidly with the third, the fourth, the fifth. He was just meeting the ball easily, however, not smashing it."

Talese becomes his readers' eyes, ears, and senses.

Television commentary can call something a "crackling shot" and move on. Sound and spectacle do the work. But on the page, how does the reader imagine that shot

if you do not show it to them? How do they see it, feel it, and place themselves inside it?

Few writers understood it better than the late Peter Roebuck. "Tendulkar might lose his wicket cheaply, but he is incapable of playing an ugly stroke. His defence might have been designed by Christopher Wren. And alongside these muscular orthodoxies could be found ornate flicks through the on-side, glides off his bulky pads that sent tight deliveries dashing on unexpected journeys into the back and beyond. Viv Richards could terrorise an attack with pitiless brutality, Lara could dissect bowlers with surgical and magical strokes, Tendulkar can take an attack apart with towering simplicity," Roebuck wrote in a *Sportstar* Cover Story, 'Celebrating Sachin Tendulkar', on November 14, 2009.

Picture a Tendulkar cover drive. The front foot moves forward without haste. The head stays still. The bat comes down late, almost discreetly, meeting the ball beneath the eyes. There is only timing. The ball runs along the turf towards the boundary, chased by a fielder who knows, almost immediately, that the race is lost.

Moments like these are why reading sport still matters. On the page, the game slows down just enough for you to notice what television rushes past.

Good sports writing trusts that if the moment is observed closely enough, honestly enough, the feeling will find its way to the reader on its own. You do not need to be told that something is beautiful when you have been shown how it happened.

When you write what you see, the reader is no longer reading about sport. They are there in the ground, reliving the moment with you.